among Muslims and Dalits. That empties the Congress larder. At the same time, the proximity of the hardline Raj Thackeray, it fears, could alienate North Indian voters. Even Muslim voters, the Congress feels, could be left a bit confused with Raj Thackeray in the MVA orbit.

THE MNS FACTOR

It may sound illogical to say the MNS will repel voters from the Congress but not the Sena (UBT), the actual party to the détente. But who says politics can't contain contraries—or that a selfless national party can't develop selfish needs. Says a Congress senior: "The UBT gains from our votes, while its voters don't support us to the same extent." Then the crunch line: "We would like to consolidate our voters so that they don't get used to voting for the UBT."

After the assembly poll drubbing, it's vital for the UBT to regain control over the BMC—India's richest civic body, with a Rs 74,000 crore purse. Control over it has historically helped the Sena foster a "reward economy" for its cadre. That's now imperilled, UBT leaders admit. The Marathi plus Muslim combine had helped it win three Lok Sabha seats and 10 of its modest assembly haul of 20 in Mumbai.

Working-class Marathis formed the undivided Sena's core base. The BJP leans on forward-caste Maharashtrians and non-Marathi groups like Gujaratis, Marwaris, Jains and North Indians. Changing demographics have of late loaded the dice against the Sena's old nativist line. As an MNS source admits, these groups have closed ranks with the BJP. Any Marathi mobilisation may be met with a counter-mobilisation. Also, of the 100 corporators in the Sena camp in the house that lapsed in 2022, the Eknath Shinde faction has weaned away around 50.

In 2017, the undivided Sena had fought alone and won 84 seats of 227 seats; the BJP rose to 82 but didn't wish to upset its state-level partner. So, after a 1985-92 reign, the Sena's second innings at the BMC was extended—from 1997 up to 2022. Due to legal disputes over delimitation and caste quotas for the wards, BMC polls have not been held since 2017. The fight now is to determine the next set of elected representatives. ■

Takeaways

- The Congress feels the presence of MNS in the MVA will repel North Indian vote
- Also, it feels Uddhav may wean away some of its own Dalit and Muslim voters
- BMC polls are being held after a gap of eight years. Winning is vital for Sena UBT

▶ TAMIL NADU

FLAME OF CONFLICT

The BJP brings out its old playbook to prise open the Dravidian heartland. An ancient Madurai temple becomes ground zero for the rituals of majoritarianism

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

AN AYODHYA IN TAMIL NADU?

Unlikely venue, it would seem, but the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) seems willing to move mountains in its efforts to reframe the state's cultural landscape through its polarising narrative. Thus, a long-settled dispute over a sacred hill in Madurai has been reopened and shoved back into the spotlight. The Subramaniya Swamy Temple, nestled at the base of the Thirupparankundram Hill, is one of the six sites associated with the veneration of Subramanian or Murugan (as Karthikeya is called here). The Karthigai Deepam festival at this rock-cut cave shrine—or lamp-lighting during the month of Karthika—is a ritual in the ancient Tamil Shaivite tradition referenced as long back as the Sangam texts. But if right-wing groups have their way, it needs to shift venue—moving up that rocky hill.

Why? A 14th century dargah stands at the top of the hill. For ages, it evoked not violence but a shared sacredness of place. Well, mostly. In 1920, getting into the high noon of British divide and rule, ownership of the hill itself became a communal and legal flashpoint. It was settled in favour of the temple, barring the dargah area. So far, so good.

But it so happens that there's also a pillar near the dargah, referred to by Hindu groups as *deepathoonu*. In 1994, in the charged aftermath of the Babri Masjid demolition, it became a local instrument for the pan-Indian politics that projected Hindu sites awaiting reclama-